



CALIPH Muhammad's successors as leaders of Islam were known as caliphs (from the Arabic *Khalifat ar-Rasul Allah*, "the successor, representative of the Prophet of God"), and the area over which they ruled was known as the caliphate.

Dome of the Rock

The Dome of the Rock mosque in Jerusalem is the oldest surviving monument from the early period of Islam. First built in the 7th century, it has been restored and redecored several times since. The site is sacred not only to Muslims, but also to Jews and Christians, and has been a lasting source of conflict.

While early caliphs had been chosen by community leaders, under the Umayyads the position became hereditary. To improve the government of their expanding empire, the Umayyads moved their capital to the more central Damascus, and borrowed institutions from the Byzantine and Persian rulers of the area, simply changing the administrative language to Arabic.

The Umayyads continued the conquests of previous caliphs, consolidating power over the former Persian Empire and extending the rule of Islam across North Africa. They built monumental shrines and places of worship to emphasize Islamic power, including the Dome of the Rock, on the site in Jerusalem where Muhammad is believed to have ascended to heaven, and great mosques at Damascus, Aleppo, and Medina. Although conversion was still by choice, special taxes on non-Muslims and religious restrictions on senior government positions encouraged the population to become increasingly Muslim and to adopt Arab customs, particularly in the east of the empire, in what are now Iraq and Iran.

Despite all this, factionalism remained rife, with several groups trying to seize power from the Umayyads. One major group still believed that only the descendants of 'Ali, who had lost in the civil war that brought the Umayyads to power, should rule. When one of 'Ali's sons was killed, they proclaimed him a martyr. The resulting dispute triggered



one of the biggest splits in Islam and 'Ali's followers ultimately became the Shia branch of Islam.

In 750, several anti-Umayyad factions joined together to overthrow their rulers. The leader of the revolt was descended from another relative of Muhammad, named 'Abbas.

The Abbasid dynasty

The family of 'Abbas was largely based in the old Persian Empire—modern-day Iran, Iraq, and Afghanistan. They moved the capital east to the new city of Baghdad, which was closer to their center of power, located on major trade routes,

Arab astrolabe

The astrolabe was an astronomical device developed in the Islamic world that used the position of the sun and stars for navigation, and as a tool to locate Mecca.



and closer to fertile farming areas. The new rulers ruthlessly wiped out anyone they perceived as a threat, and replaced the old Umayyad officials with those loyal to them. The Abbasids used a system of intelligence to spy on officials in far-off countries, to make sure they did not get too powerful. They used the words of the Qur'an and Islamic law to justify their claims to power and to further secure their position. They also introduced a more formal system of taxation to pay for their armies and bureaucrats. The Abbasid period is generally considered a golden age of Islamic art, science, and architecture. Arabic became increasingly important as both a religious and a political language. Large encyclopedias and collections of lore were commissioned, and translations made of Greek and Persian scientific treatises, philosophical works, and literary texts.

(see pp.158–59). Without these Arabic copies, the modern world would probably know very little about Greek and Persian literature, and the technological advances of the scientific revolution (see pp.266–67) and after might have been much delayed.

Despite their best efforts, the Abbasids were unable to prevent further revolts and uprisings among their subjects. In the mid-10th century, the Buyids, a group of professional soldiers employed by the Abbasids, staged a coup and took over the caliphate. Content to operate out of sight, they allowed the Abbasids to retain their title, and the Abbasid caliphate survived in name until the arrival of the Mongols in the 13th century.

DECISIVE MOMENT

BATTLE OF BADR

The Battle of Badr was crucial to the foundation of Islam. Taking place on March 17, 624, it is one of the few battles mentioned in the Qur'an. The Quraishi rulers of Mecca, frustrated by early Muslim ambushes on caravans in the area, launched a concerted attempt to stop them, but despite overwhelming odds in their favor they were soundly defeated. This illustration of the pursuit of the defeated army comes from a later account of the battle. Victory consolidated the political position of Muhammad and forced the surrounding areas to take him seriously.

“[The] Arabs... will stand in awe of us forever.”

AMR IBN HISHAM, ISLAMIC COMMANDER AT BADR, 624 CE

